

*Popcorn and
the Castle
of Dreams*

Popcorn and the Castle of Dreams is a magical journey through the world of sleep and children's imagination. Among dragons, pizza and volcanoes, fears become adventures, fantasies are confused with reality, and even the fiercest of guardians reveals his vulnerability. Written in the form of a narrative ballad, the book celebrates the transformative power of dreams and the beauty – and wonder – of growing up.

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Popcorn and the Castle of Dreams

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Illustrations created with the help of Sora and ChatGPT.



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To Anna Beatriz, who teaches me to dream with my eyes open – and to tell stories to all the children who are afraid of sleeping; and to those who discovered that sleep can be an adventure, dreamed of dragons and woke up hungry.



Sleeping isn't always easy – especially when you're a child. There's the fear of the dark, the fear of the unknown, the fear of missing out on what's happening in the outside world... and the fear of waking up not knowing where you are.

But sleep can also be a portal – and a path. In this book, little Pipoca embarks on a fantastic journey, where dragons like pizza, volcanoes erupt, and a mysterious fox points the way.

The story is told like a ballad: a narrative poem with rhythm and rhyme – like the old songs that were passed down from generation to generation.

Here and there, you can find echoes of Alice diving down the rabbit hole, the myth of Orpheus and Eurydice, or Plato's Cave.

But above all, you'll find a child's dream: confusing, vibrant, full of symbols and discoveries.

I hope this book accompanies the reader – young or old – like a story told in the hammock, just before going to sleep.



Popcorn was leaping all over the floor,
His wooden sword swinging, mid-battle roar.
He shouted and jumped in a wild display,
Till Mama called out, her voice far away:

– "It's nap time now, come rest your head!"
– "But I want to play!" the little one said.
To help her dino rest and unwind,
She dimmed the lights to soothe his mind.



She reached for a book on the old wooden shelf,
Its cover a dragon, fierce as itself.
She sat in the hammock and gave it a swing,
And Pipcorn, intrigued, curled up like a king.



Then Mama began, in the soft fading light:
– “It’s the tale of Morpheus, dragon of night,
Who guarded the castle of Hypnos the king,
Who couldn’t find rest – not a wink, not a thing.”

A dark, atmospheric illustration of a castle on a hill and a dragon by a river at night. The castle, with its tall tower and crenellated walls, is silhouetted against a twilight sky. Warm light emanates from its windows and a ground-level archway. In the foreground, a large, dark dragon with a single glowing yellow eye is coiled on the right bank of a river. The river flows from the castle towards the dragon, reflecting the ambient light. The background features rolling hills and a crescent moon under a starry night sky.

Morpheus was mighty, fierce, and grand,
And older than any in the realm of sand.
He was wise, enormous, and truly brave,
With eyes like fire in a twilight cave.

Beside the River of sweet Oblivion,
That sang a lullaby, a soft delusion,
The king built his tower close to its stream,
To drift into sleep with the flow of a dream.

But as with all creatures of power and might,
He carried a weakness hidden from sight:
Morpheus longed for pizza and treats,
More than a guard – the hungriest of beasts.



Then came a knight, both clever and sly,
Who learned of the secret and gleam in his eye.
He carried a pizza tied to his side,
And slipped past the gate as the dragon was beguiled.

Then, with courage and a clever plan in hand,
The knight crossed the darkness, firm did stand.
He seized the moment, while the dragon's guard was low,
And slipped through the gate with steps soft and mellow.

A large, friendly-looking orange dragon is sitting in a hammock, holding an open book. A smaller, similar dragon is curled up in its arms, appearing to be asleep. The scene is set at night, with a dark blue background and some faint, glowing light spots. The dragon's eyes are closed, and it has a gentle smile. The book it is holding has a red dragon on the cover. The hammock is made of a light brown material and is suspended by ropes. The overall mood is peaceful and cozy.

As he listened, he slowly grew still,
His eyelids drooping, the night calm and chill.
In a gentle breath, without a faintest stir,
Popcorn soon drifted to sleep, just a soft whirr.

...in a dream both strange and new,
He found himself in a courtyard view.
Stone walls, gray as the night,
Towers rose, gates out of sight.



There, right in the middle, a sight of blur,
A gentle fox, with rust-red fur.
It moved with grace, so soft and light,
Its gaze was warm, its steps polite.



She gazed upon a half-open door,
Leading to darkness, deep and more.
It seemed the gateway to a dungeon's lair-
A cold wind gripped him, chilling the air.

Popcorn, curious, followed her lead,
Treading softly, careful in deed.
Turning the corner, what did he find?
The fox stood still, calm and kind.

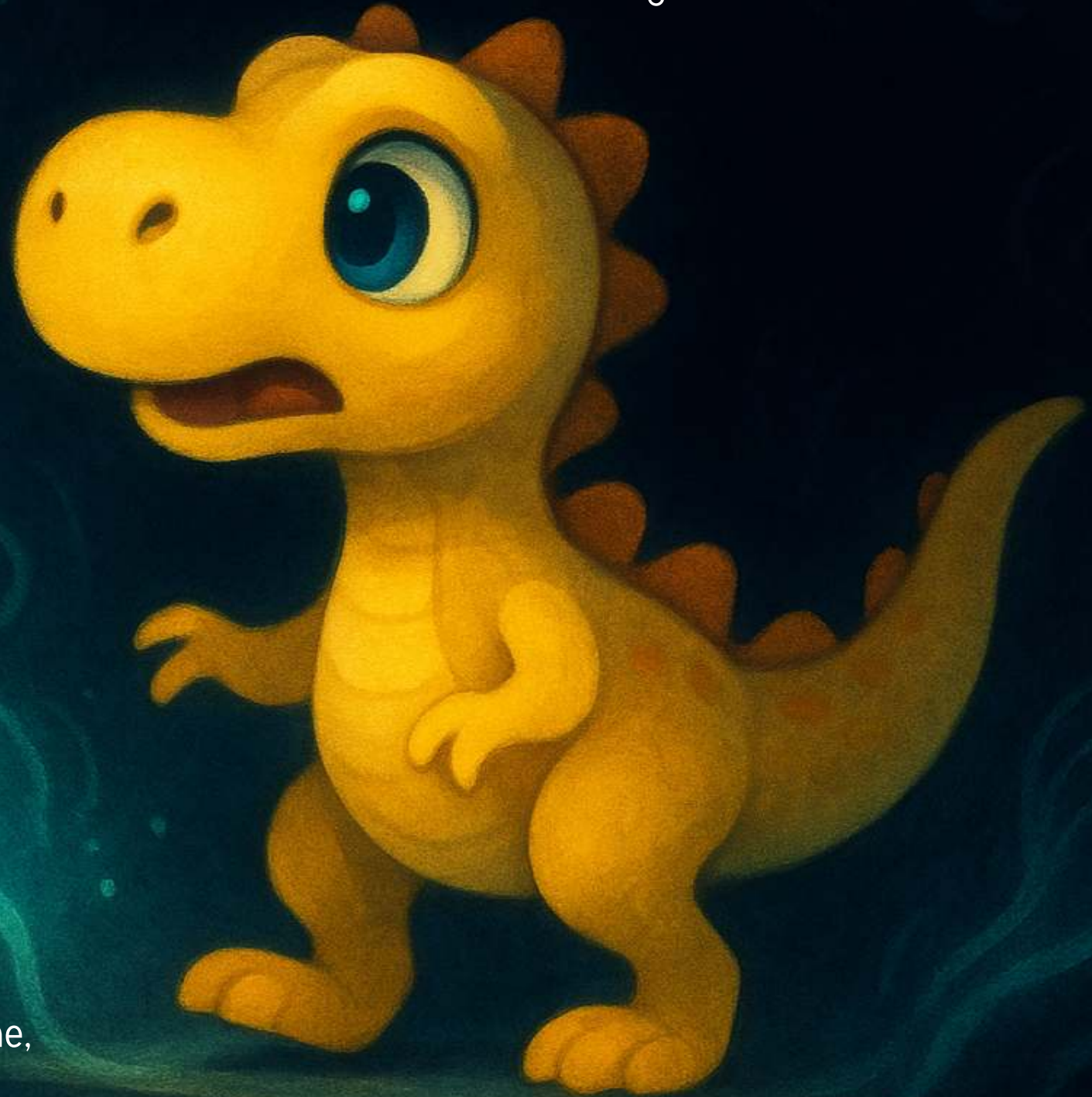


His rust-red tail, a fading glow,
The last bright color he'd come to know.
Like something dreamed beyond his sight,
He moved with caution, dread in plight.



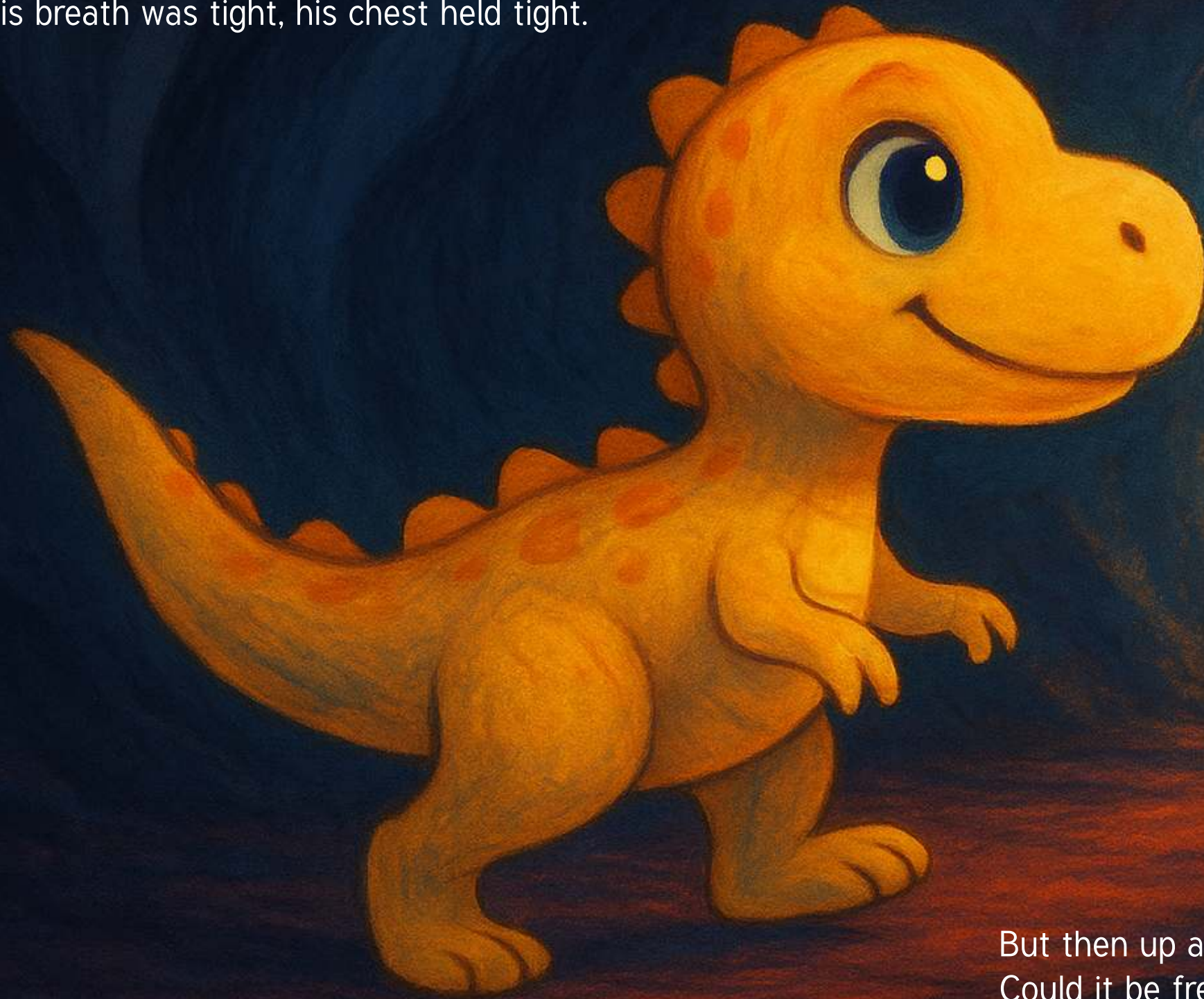
He stepped inside, not to be mislead,
Fear in his heart, but courage ahead.
The darkness wrapped so cold, so still,
An echoing void, a silent chill.

But he missed a step, on ground unsure,
And tumbled down into shadow obscure.
“Careful! Beware!” the darkness cried,
As growls and howls echoed inside.



But then through the air came a curious tune,
A melody soft, like a pull from the moon.
It shimmered with beauty, gentle and deep,
As if every note had a promise to keep.

He landed below in a tunnel of gloom,
His fingers reached out through the shadowed room.
He moved with care, no path in sight,
His breath was tight, his chest held tight.



But then up ahead, a glimmering glow –
Could it be freedom? He hoped it so!
His heart eased up, relief was a vision,
Perhaps he'd escape from the tunnel of Oblivion.

At last he emerged, high over the land,
On the towering peak of a mountain so grand.
There stood a volcano, roaring with might,
Spewing its fire in a terrible sight!



Popcorn stood trembling, ready to flee,
But something strange stirred suddenly.
He felt a great weight, turned with surprise —
Two wings had spread from his back to the skies!



His wings gave a flap, instinctive and wide,
And lifted up Popcorn in powerful stride.
He soared past the peak, the smoke, and the flame,
Far from the fear and fire no one can tame.

O'er valleys and hills he flew with grace,
Till a shimmering lake appeared in place.
He dove through the air and landed below,
Gasping for air, his eyes all aglow.

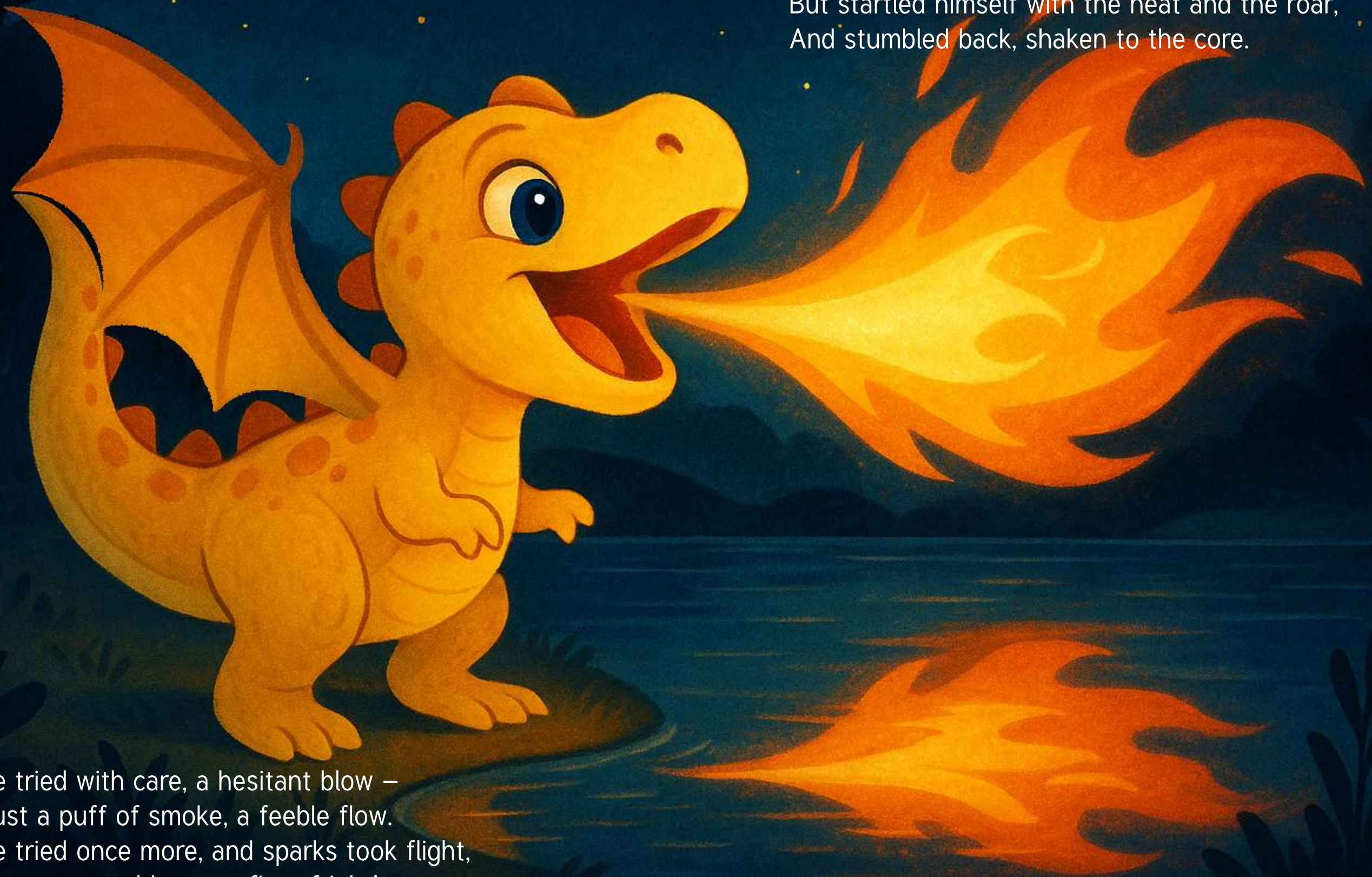


"Wow! I'm a dragon!" he cried in delight,
In wonder and awe at the magical sight.
"Could I breathe fire?" he thought with a grin,
And send a bright blaze from within?

He knelt by the shore and looked down below,
To find a reflection he ought to know.
But staring back with a startled gleam
Was a scaled, bright creature from some old dream.

He laughed aloud in a joyful cheer,
Then roared out a flame, bold and clear.
But startled himself with the heat and the roar,
And stumbled back, shaken to the core.

He tried with care, a hesitant blow –
Just a puff of smoke, a feeble flow.
He tried once more, and sparks took flight,
Then came a blast – a fiery fright!



Popcorn tried words, gentle and plain,
But the knight heard only a growl of flame.
He meant to say, "I won't bring you harm!"
But thundered so loud, it raised an alarm!



All at once, a sound made him spin –
A knight on a steed was galloping in.
Upon his tall horse, with a startled face,
He stared at the dragon, frozen in place.

Popcorn's eyes sparkled, lit with delight,
He took a big bite—what a glorious sight!
Soon they were laughing, side by side,
A feast unexpected, with joy as their guide.



The knight, still shaking, a little amused,
Opened a box, can't be refused.
Inside was pizza, a warm sign of trust,
With bubbling cheese and a crisp golden crust.



And so he kept dreaming, wrapped in delight,
In a world full of wonder, color, and light.
Not even in verse, so dreamy and spry,
Could he leave his pizza just waving goodbye!



"Pipoca and the Castle of Dreams" is more than a bedtime story – it is a journey. Through a poetic narrative, it explores, with lightness and depth, the symbolic territory of childhood sleep – a space of transition between reality and imagination, between childhood and development.

Pipoca's journey begins like so many childhood nights: with reluctance, games and an invitation to rest. But when he falls asleep, he plunges into a dream world in which symbolic figures and fantastic situations make up an archetypal narrative.

The story dialogues with different mythical and philosophical traditions. By following an ethereal fox through a dark tunnel, Pipoca approaches the myth of Orpheus, who descends into the underworld in search of Eurydice. Like Orpheus, Pipoca is guided by a figure who represents the link with the known world. The soft music that initially attracts him – and which soon becomes chaos and noise – is reminiscent of Orpheus's lyre: a hypnotic call that opens paths but guarantees no return.

Pipoca's dreamlike journey also echoes Alice in Wonderland, whose fall down the rabbit hole leads her to a world of abrupt physical transformations, where size, shape, and logic falter. Like Alice, Pipoca transforms – literally – throughout his journey. His wings emerge not as a symbol of absolute power, but as a response to fear, loss, and the unknown.

In this process, the tunnel he traverses represents the underworld – the place of shadows, confusion, and confrontation with what is strange and threatening. It is a space for dissolving the previous form and preparing for something new. Upon emerging from the tunnel, already transformed, Pipoca faces a new danger: an erupting volcano. The transition does not grant him immediate peace, but rather places him before a new stage of his journey.

The book also evokes Plato's allegory of the Cave, when it treats sleep as a space of limited and illusory perception. Like prisoners who mistake shadows for reality, Pipoca lives intensely in the world of dreams – until, upon waking, everything seems distant and irreversible. Childhood, in this sense, is our first cave: where we learn to discern what we see, feel and believe.

The mythological references extend to the setting: Hypnos, the Greek god of sleep, is reimagined as the king of a castle on the banks of the river of oblivion, in a direct allusion to the dreamlike geography of Greek myths. His guardian, the dragon Morpheus – the name of the god of dreams – represents both danger and dormant wisdom, and carries with it the classic notion that even the most powerful being has a weak spot.

In the end, Pipoca is still dreaming... His adventure is a rite of passage in the form of a dream: comical, poetic, frightening and liberating. And as with the most striking dreams, perhaps he will remember everything – or perhaps it will all evaporate with the first rays of sunlight. But something remains: the crossing made, and the silent certainty that there is much more to us than we imagine.